

nable to read his own history, and not see that this struggle was merely between different branches of the same family of Medici for the sovereignty, and that there was not a ray of public virtue or love of liberty left in any of them? Strozzi, the rival family of Medici, had married a Medici, and could not bear that Alexander should rule. His character was too vile to be redeemed from infamy by his hypocritical affectation of republican simplicity, and his renouncing all titles but that of Philip; but he had great family connections, and was countenanced by France, and therefore might possibly recover his influence and power in Florence. This made it dangerous for the historian to mark the conduct of Lorenzo with that decided indignation which it merited. Some were of opinion that he was moved to this action merely by the malice of his nature, and the depravity of his own heart; others thought that he ventured on this danger to cancel the ignominy of the two Roman proclamations, and the oration made against him by Molza; others thought him agitated solely by a desire to make his name immortal, an ardent passion, that with all his crimes and vices had always incredibly tormented him. The right of a nation to depose a tyrant, and to destroy him if he cannot be otherwise deposed, is as clear as any of our ideas of right or wrong. In the Roman republic it was made an early and a fundamental law, by the aristocrats however, that it should be not only lawful, but meritorious and glorious, to kill a tyrant; and Brutus therefore acted the exalted part of the best citizen. But if the right of single citizens, when good and virtuous, and intending only the public good, to kill a tyrant was as clear as that of treading on the head of an adder, or hunting down a devouring

ing

ing wolf, it would by no means follow that one tyrant might claim a right to destroy another, merely to take his place. The people of Florence were now so totally devoted to the Medici family, that there was no party among them but what was headed by some branch of it: the blood of the Medici must in all events govern them; and the difference between them was worth very little. Strozzi and Lorenzo were worse than Alexander; and the only tolerably good man among them was Cosimo, whom they all hated, but whom Providence was pleased to call to the government in this awful manner. The silly tales of prognostics, the enthusiasm of the disciples of Savanarola, and the confusions and terrors among the principal people upon the first suspicion and final discovery of the duke's destiny, are not worth repeating. The council of forty-eight were assembled, but were not agreed in opinion. Canigiani proposed, that in place of the deceased duke, Guilio, his natural son, should succeed; but there was no other person present, who did not either smile at his folly, or express an indignation; for besides that the child was not five years old, this was known to be the inclination and secret motion of cardinal Cibo, Lorenzo's brother, who wished to be the tutor, and therefore governor of the city. After him was proposed the signor Cosimo de Medici, who knowing nothing of what had happened, was at Mugello, fifteen miles from Florence, at his country seat of Trebbio. At this nomination all appeared to be struck, and looking at one another, seemed ready to accept it, every one knowing that Cosimo was the next heir, after Lorenzo, according to the declaration of the emperor; but Palla Rucellai, without doubt in favour of Philip Strozzi, to whom he was attached, opposed warmly
this

this proposition, and said, that so many citizens, and of such consequence, were abroad, that nothing of importance, especially so great an affair, ought to be determined on; and notwithstanding all that was urged by Francesco Guicchiardini, and Francesco Vettori, he persisted obstinately in his objections, and occasioned some confusion in council. At another day, however, Cosimo was elected head of the commonwealth, accepted the trust, and behaved in it with so much wisdom, that those who, from his moderate and composed behaviour before, believed him to be possessed of but mean abilities, were constrained to confess, that God had granted him discretion with the dukedom.

Intelligence was scattered throughout all Italy, with incredible celerity, of the death of Alexander; and, by all the Florentine exiles, the name of Lorenzo di Pierfrancesco de Medici was exalted in praises to the skies, not only as the parallel of Brutus, but greatly surpassing him. Varchi wonders that so many citizens of so great prudence, and especially Guicchiardini, who conducted the whole of this election, should have suffered themselves to be so far blinded and transported by their ambition or avarice, or both, as not to see what they were about. Indeed, no man is ever to be praised, perhaps never to be justified, in consenting to the surrender of a free government; and Guicchiardini appears much to blame for not endeavouring to new-model the commonwealth upon this occasion. But most probably he knew, what Varchi himself confesses*, that the Florentines were at this time all either avaricious or ambitious, and the major part of them proud, envious, and malicious; and therefore that none of them

* Varchi, p. 621.